

Google Maps API keys, step by step

For the Shero Home Food WhatsApp ordering page. It takes about 15 minutes. You need the Google account the business will own, and a payment card for billing.

What you will set up

Google API	Needed?	What the bot uses it for
Maps JavaScript API	Yes	Shows Google's map, with the pin, on the address form
Geocoding API	Yes	Turns a map pin into a street address, finds an address typed in the search box, and looks up ZIP codes
Places API (Autocomplete)	No - do not enable	The bot does not use it

Key	Allowed API	.env name	Why
Server key	Geocoding API only	GOOGLE_MAPS_API_KEY	Stays on the server, never seen by customers
Browser key	Maps JavaScript API only	GOOGLE_MAPS_BROWSER_KEY	Visible in the web page, so it is locked to our website address

Cost

Each API has **10,000 free uses a month**. One order uses about one map load and a few address lookups, so normal use stays free. Step 3 adds a budget alert so a bill can never surprise you. Prices: <https://mapsplatform.google.com/pricing/>

You will need

Keep these ready before you start:

- The business Google account (a company account, not a personal one)
- A company payment card
- The ordering page address: **<https://shero-order-bot.locat.it>** (and your own domain later, for example <https://order.sherohomefood.com>)

1 Open Google Cloud Console

1. Go to **<https://console.cloud.google.com/>**
2. Sign in with the business Google account.
3. If asked, accept the Terms of Service and choose your country (**United States**).

2 Create a project

1. At the top left, click the **project picker** (next to "Google Cloud").
2. Click **New Project**. Direct link: <https://console.cloud.google.com/projectcreate>
3. Fill in the form, then click **Create**:

Field on the screen	Type or choose exactly
Project name	Shero Home Food
Organization / Location	Leave as it is

- Open the project picker again and select **Shero Home Food**. Check that its name shows in the top bar before you continue. Every later step must be in this project.

3 Turn on billing and a budget alert

1. Go to <https://console.cloud.google.com/billing>
2. Click **Link a billing account** (or **Create account** if there is none) and enter the company card.
3. Make sure the billing account is linked to the **Shero Home Food** project.
4. Go to **Billing** → **Budgets & alerts** → **Create budget** and enter:

Field on the screen	Type or choose exactly
Name	Shero Google Maps
Projects	Shero Home Food
Amount (Target amount)	10 USD per month
Alert thresholds	50%, 90%, 100% (the defaults)
Email alerts to	Billing admins and users (tick it)

4 Enable the two APIs

1. Open console.cloud.google.com/apis/library/geocoding-backend.googleapis.com It shows **Geocoding API**. Click **Enable**.
2. Open console.cloud.google.com/apis/library/maps-backend.googleapis.com It shows **Maps JavaScript API**. Click **Enable**.
3. Do **not** enable Places API or any other API.

Or use the main menu (the three lines at the top left) → APIs & Services → Library, search each name and click Enable. Check that the top bar still shows Shero Home Food.

5 Create key 1: the server key

1. Go to <https://console.cloud.google.com/apis/credentials>
2. Click + **Create credentials** → **API key**. A key appears; it starts with **Alza**.
3. Click **Edit API key** (or the key's name in the list) and set:

Field on the screen	Type or choose exactly
Name	Shero server key
Application restrictions	None for now. When the bot moves to its own server, change this to IP addresses and add that server's IP.

Field on the screen	Type or choose exactly
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API restrictions Restrict key → tick only Geocoding API

- Click **Save**, then **Show key**, and copy it. This is `GOOGLE_MAPS_API_KEY`.

6 Create key 2: the browser key

- On the same Credentials page, click + **Create credentials** → **API key** again.
- Click **Edit API key** and set:

Field on the screen	Type or choose exactly
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Name Shero browser key

Application restrictions Websites

Website restrictions → Add `https://shero-order-bot.loca.lt/*`

Add another (later) Your own domain when the bot moves, for example
`https://order.sherohomefood.com/*`

API restrictions Restrict key → tick only Maps JavaScript API

- Click **Save** and copy this key too. This is `GOOGLE_MAPS_BROWSER_KEY`.

Type the website exactly, including `https://` and the `/*` at the end. New keys and changed restrictions can take up to 5 minutes to start working.

7 Put the keys into the bot

Option A - the .env file in the project folder. These are all the Google-related lines. Fill in the first two; leave the others exactly as shown:

```
# --- Geocoding / distance ---
GOOGLE_MAPS_API_KEY=AiZa...the server key from step 5...
GOOGLE_MAPS_BROWSER_KEY=AiZa...the browser key from step 6...
DISTANCE_MODE=haversine
GEOCODER_COUNTRY=US

# --- already set; must match the browser key's website (step 6) ---
PUBLIC_BASE_URL=https://shero-order-bot.loca.lt
```

.env line	Value	Notes
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<code>GOOGLE_MAPS_API_KEY</code>	The server key (step 5)	Required for accurate street addresses and house numbers
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<code>GOOGLE_MAPS_BROWSER_KEY</code>	The browser key (step 6)	Required for Google's map on the address form
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.env line	Value	Notes
DISTANCE_MODE	haversine	Leave as is. Delivery distance is measured in a straight line; road distance is not built
GEOCODER_COUNTRY	US	Leave as is. Keeps address search inside the US
PUBLIC_BASE_URL	The ordering page address	Already set. If it changes, add the new address to the browser key too

After editing .env, the server must be restarted for the keys to load.

Option B - Admin dashboard → Settings → Maps. Paste the server key into **Google Maps API Key (server: Geocoding API)** and the browser key into **Google Maps Browser Key**, then click Save. This works within a minute, with no restart.

Keep the keys private

Never send the keys over WhatsApp, email, chat or in screenshots. Paste them only into .env or the Admin Settings page, and never put the server key in the browser key's place.

8 Check that it works

1. On WhatsApp, send **new link** to the bot and open the menu link.
2. Add a dish, go to the address step, and tap **+ Add a new address**.
3. The map should now be Google's map, not the OpenStreetMap one.
4. Move the pin: the street address should fill in, with the house number.

If something goes wrong

What you see	How to fix it
The page still shows the OpenStreetMap map	The browser key is missing, or (Option A) the server was not restarted. Or the page address is not in the key's Websites list: check the spelling and the /* at the end.
"This page can't load Google Maps correctly"	Maps JavaScript API is not enabled, billing is not linked, or the website restriction does not match the page address.
The address does not fill in when the pin moves	Server key: Geocoding API is not enabled, or the key is restricted to the wrong API. The bot then falls back to the free OpenStreetMap lookup.
"REQUEST_DENIED" or "billing not enabled"	Go back to step 3 and link billing to the Shero Home Food project.
It worked before but not on the new domain	Add the new domain to the browser key's Websites list (step 6) and update PUBLIC_BASE_URL.

Without any Google keys the bot still works. It uses the free OpenStreetMap map and address lookups, which are less accurate and often miss house numbers.